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Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

SHARJAH BOOK FAIR BEGINS

Artistes entertain visitors on the opening day of the 45th Sharjah International Book Fair 2026 at Expo Centre. The fair, under the theme 'Made of Stories', runs until November 15 and features 3,212 publishers and exhibitors from 126 countries, showcasing 1.7 million titles spanning different languages, cultures and genres. **SEE ALSO P4**

Trump faces Iran test after midterm rout

WAR, RISING COSTS FUEL BACKLASH AS US PRESIDENT WEIGHS NEXT MOVE

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump faced a political reckoning yesterday after Democrats swept the US midterm elections, seizing control of both chambers of Congress as voter anger over the Iran war and rising living costs delivered a devastating blow to his Republican Party.

The sweeping defeat raised fresh questions about the direction of American policy towards Iran and the wider Middle East, with Trump retaining the power to launch fresh military strikes despite his weakened political position. In a striking admission, Trump acknowledged that the conflict with Iran had contributed to the defeat, even as he defended launching the war in February.

"I think a part of it was Iran," Trump told Fox News. But he insisted he had made the right decision, telling *The Wall Street Journal*: "I would have done it again."

Democrats captured the Senate and House of Representatives, making historic gains in Republican strongholds including Texas, Kansas and South Carolina. They also secured major governorship victories. An AP voter survey found roughly three-quarters of voters angry or dissatisfied with the country's direction, while many blamed Trump's policies for higher prices.

Iran seized on the results as evidence of American opposition to the conflict. "Americans said NO TO WAR, and we endorse this message," Iranian parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf declared.

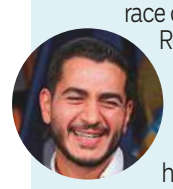
But the Democratic victory does not necessarily mean an end to military confrontation.

"Every time Trump has been backed into a corner, he has shouted more and come out fighting," Peter Loge, director of George Washington University's School of Media and Public Affairs, told AFP.

Reuters reported that some Gulf governments believe Trump's election setback could push him towards a diplomatic settlement with Iran rather than another major military offensive. But others fear Tehran could misinterpret his weakened position as a sign of American weakness, raising the risk of renewed confrontation.

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MAKING HISTORY



Democrat **Abdul El Sayed** won Michigan's US Senate race over former Republican lawmaker Mike Rogers, US networks said yesterday, making him the first Muslim elected to the upper chamber of Congress.

UAE announces star ratings

Traffic and Licensing Services Centre in Fujairah gets 7 stars

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, announced the results of the sixth cycle of the Global Star Rating System for Services 2026.

The Traffic and Licensing Services Centre in Fujairah, part of the Ministry of Interior, achieved a 7-star rating, the first service channel to do so since the system was launched in 2011. The cycle assessed 179 service channels across 27 federal government entities, making it the largest ever.

Best global practices

Sheikh Mohammed said that improving government services and the customer experience will always remain a priority for the UAE Government, stressing the need to keep raising the efficiency and quality of services and to adopt the best global practices in delivering them, so that they meet society's aspirations and improve people's quality of life.

Overall government performance improved on previous cycles. The 179 channels assessed included 107 service centres, 49 digital channels and 23 call centres.

One channel received 7 stars, 8 received 6 stars, 67 received 5 stars, 70 received 4 stars and 33 received 3 stars.

Call centres recorded the strongest improvement at 13 per cent, followed by service centres at 5 per cent and digital channels at 4 per cent, reflecting the steady efforts of government entities to strengthen their channels and respond more effectively to customer needs. Service centres delivered the highest overall performance, followed by digital channels.



SPORT

'I don't feel there's any risk': McIlroy backs UAE golf events | P15



ABU DHABI

Al Ain Museum: Preserving UAE's heritage | P IV

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